GinCol Lab · Aula

Student worksheet

Contemporary World History · 1st year of Bachillerato · The historian's craft · Class 3 of 6 · With Tristán

Did the Wall open by mistake?

Class video: https://youtu.be/7esRl9d2e3Y

The code leads to the video.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Before you start: your bet

On 9 November 1989, an East German leader made a mistake at a live press conference, and a few hours later the Berlin Wall opened. **If nobody had made a mistake that night, would the Wall still be standing?** Tick one and explain why in one sentence.

1. Yes, for many more years.

2. No: it would have opened anyway, sooner or later.

3. There's no way of knowing.

At the end of the class. What evidence would make you change your bet?

While you watch the video

1. The paper Schabowski read out said "ab sofort", with immediate effect. What did that mean in the East German administration?

2. What was the paper written for? What does it tell without meaning to?

3. What had the regime decided, and what had it not decided?

4. Name the four underlying causes and one piece of evidence for each.

The exodus chart

East Germans arriving in the West in 1989 (Bundesausgleichsamt; Chronik der Mauer).

Month	Arrivals	With the regime's permission	Without permission
April	5,887	4,996	
May	10,642	9,115	
August	20,955	12,812	
September	33,255	11,903	

1. Fill in the last column.

2. In May, the figure almost doubles, and that same month Hungary starts taking down the barbed-wire fence on its border with Austria. Was that why? Argue it with the numbers in the table.

3. In which month does the Hungarian border show most? Why?

Underlying cause, trigger or consequence?

Mark **U** (underlying cause), **T** (trigger or part of it), **I** (immediate consequence) or **L** (lasting consequence).

1. Thousands of East Germans leave through Hungary and Czechoslovakia.

2. Schabowski answers "sofort, unverzüglich".

3. Gorbachev says that changing a country's system is a matter for its people.

4. On Saturday 11 November, around one and a half million visits to West Berlin.

5. On 3 October 1990, Germany becomes a single country again.

6. A report says the country is on the brink of bankruptcy.

7. West German television reports the border as open ahead of time.

Practice

1. **Sarajevo, 28 June 1914.** A 19-year-old Serb student from Bosnia kills the heir to the Austro-Hungarian Empire; a month later, Austria-Hungary declares war on Serbia. Is that assassination an underlying cause or the trigger of the First World War? Name two underlying causes you remember from lower secondary school (ESO).

2. **A front page from 10 November 1989.** Find one in an open newspaper library: *ABC* (abc.es/archivo), the Biblioteca Virtual de Prensa Histórica (prensahistorica.mcu.es) or the Hemeroteca Nacional Digital de México (hndm.iib.unam.mx). Ask it the four questions. What verb does the headline use? Which cause does it give most weight to?

3. **Remove the opening of the Hungarian border.** Imagine Hungary had not opened its border in September. What would have changed, and what not? Argue it with the causes from the class, and present it as what it is: a hypothesis.

Keep thinking

What moves history: great forces or particular people, like the officer who opened a barrier without orders? Write down your position and the best argument for the opposite one.

GinCol Lab worksheet, made with AI (Claude, by Anthropic) and reviewed by a person · CC BY 4.0 · Source and errata